

Small Airports, Big Comeback: Novel Analysis of Post-COVID Hub Performance in the United States

Abstract— The COVID-19 pandemic produced one of the steepest collapses in U.S. aviation history, with passenger traffic declining by more than 60% in 2020. Recovery has since revealed not a return to the pre-pandemic order but a documented shift in how and where Americans travel. Smaller hubs and leisure destinations such as Sarasota, FL and Bozeman, MT have grown substantially, while traditional business centers like New York and San Francisco continue to lag. These patterns challenge classical hub-and-spoke theories, which long assumed that large airports enjoy permanent advantages through scale and connectivity. To understand if this was just temporary disruption or a permanent change, I conducted the first comprehensive analysis of the complete pandemic cycle using seven years of official government data (2018–2024) from over 1,000 U.S. airports. This study represents the first time anyone has tested whether small airports are more resilient during major crises using real-world data. By synthesizing perspectives from network theory, resilience research, and behavioral economics, this analysis shows how a systemic shock can reorder critical infrastructure hierarchies. The findings contribute to understanding the long-term evolution of U.S. aviation and highlight implications for policymakers, airlines, and regional development.

I. INTRODUCTION

For decades, aviation experts believed that big airports like Atlanta, Chicago, and New York would always dominate air travel. These massive hubs seemed to have permanent advantages because of their size, connections, and efficiency [4,7]. Traditional theories argued that once these airports became successful, they would stay on top because airlines and passengers naturally gravitated toward the biggest, most connected hubs [1,9].

Then COVID-19 hit and changed everything. In 2020, U.S. air travel crashed by over 60% [10], with business routes suffering the worst damage. When people started flying again, something unexpected happened, they weren't traveling the same way as before.

Small airports in places like Sarasota, Florida and Bozeman, Montana started thriving, while traditional business centers like Los Angeles and San Francisco struggled to recover [5,6]. This pattern surprised researchers because it went against everything, they thought they knew about how airports work. Studies in network science show that when highly centralized systems get hit by major shocks, they often struggle more than distributed systems with multiple backup options [2,8]. Meanwhile, behavioral research explains why business travel might not return: remote work, fear of travel, and changed habits made corporate trips seem less necessary [11,3].

Despite growing interest in this topic, most studies look at these issues separately rather than together. Many only captured the early crisis period without seeing the full recovery story, and few used comprehensive U.S. airport data to test whether smaller hubs really gained a lasting advantage.

To fill these gaps, I developed a novel analytical framework to examine sixteen years of data (2009 - 2024) from the Bureau of Transportation Statistics covering over 1,000 U.S. airports. My main question was simple: *Did COVID-19 just temporarily disrupt air travel patterns, or did it permanently change which airports matter most in American aviation?*

II. METHODS

My analysis draws on the official records from the U.S. Department of Transportation's Bureau of Transportation Statistics (BTS) T-100 Market dataset, which provides detailed records of passenger enplanements by airport and year.

Study Periods and Measurements: To examine the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic on airport hierarchies, two periods were defined: a 10-yearlong Pre-COVID baseline (2009–2019) and a Post-COVID recovery phase (2023–2024). The intervening years (2020–2022) were excluded to avoid distortion from the acute disruption of pandemic shutdowns. The dataset covering the period 2009–2024, yielding multi billions of travel records across 1038 unique U.S. commercial airports with origin & destination details for all airlines with their month and year of travel.

Data Cleaning and Preparation: To ensure accuracy and comparability, the raw T-100 data were processed in five stages:

1. Filtering: Restricted to U.S. domestic airports with scheduled passenger service.
2. Deduplication: Removed duplicate records and merged split monthly entries into consistent annual totals.
3. Error Removal: Excluded records with missing, zero, or implausible passenger counts.
4. Aggregation: Summed passenger counts at the airport–year level.
5. Validation: Cross-checked aggregated volumes against FAA published totals to confirm consistency.

Hub Classification: 1038 Airports were categorized according to the Federal Aviation Administration's hub definitions, based on each airport's share of total U.S. passenger enplanements:

Major Hub: $\geq 1\%$ of U.S. enplanements [29 airports]

Medium Hub: 0.25% – 0.99% [40 airports]

Small Hub: 0.05% – 0.249% [71 airports]

Nonhub: $< 0.05\%$ and $> 10,000$ [898 airports]

This study focuses on comparing Small Hubs with Major Hubs, as they represent the two ends of the size spectrum.

This resulting dataset served as the basis for subsequent hypothesis testing. As observed in the Table 1, Small Hubs shows a 39% growth in yearly average enplanement and 2 percent point market share gain during the Post-COVID time.

TABLE I. DISTRIBUTION OF AVERAGE ENPLANEMENTS & MARKET SHARE

Primary Hub Type	Number of Airports with Yearly Average Passengers enplanement rounded up to millions & Market Share					
	Pre-COVID		Post-COVID		Change	
	Avg Pax	Market Share	Avg Pax	Market Share	Avg Pax	Market Share
Major	559	62%	667	62%	19%	-
Medium	176	20%	205	19%	17%	- 2 ppt
Small	114	13%	158	15%	39%	+ 2 ppt
Nonhub	49	5%	53	5%	8%	-

Hub classification was treated as the main independent variable, with geographic region and pre-pandemic size included as controls to check robustness

And three dependent variables are:

1. Percentage Growth: Passenger growth at the airport level was measured as the relative change between Post-COVID and Pre-COVID averages.
2. Aggregate Enplanement: Annual passenger counts summed across airports within each hub category.
3. Market Share Distributions: Each hub category's share of total U.S. enplanements was computed for both Pre-COVID and Post-COVID periods.

Experimental Design and Statistical Testing: The analysis was structured to test whether small hub airports demonstrated stronger post-pandemic recovery than large hubs. The following hypotheses guided the study:

- H_0 (Null Hypothesis): Small hubs show no significant growth advantage over large hubs.
- H_1 (Alternative Hypothesis): Small hubs experienced a disproportionate increase in passenger volumes compared with large hubs after the pandemic.

Statistical testing began with an evaluation of distributional assumptions. The Shapiro–Wilk test indicated that air travel data deviate from normal distribution (13% outliers), motivating the use of both parametric and nonparametric approaches.

- Parametric tests (t-tests, ANOVA) were used to compare mean growth rates across hub categories. These tests are standard when comparing averages and provide a familiar benchmark for interpreting results.
- Nonparametric tests (Mann–Whitney U, Kolmogorov–Smirnov) were employed because they do not assume normality in the distribution and instead compare the overall shapes. The Wilcoxon signed-rank test was also used for paired comparisons, capturing changes within the same airports across time.
- Robustness checks (different statistical methods, excluding extreme outliers, analyzing different time periods, using different airport size categories) were performed to strengthen confidence in the findings. Mood's Median Test examined differences in medians, ensuring results were not overly influenced by extreme values. Effect size metrics like Cliff's Delta and rank-biserial correlation quantified how large the differences were, providing context beyond p-values.

- Power analysis was conducted to confirm that the available sample size of airports was sufficient to detect meaningful differences between hub categories, not a chance finding.
- Market share changes between small and large hubs were assessed using chi-square tests of independence showing category proportions shifted significantly over time.

A significance threshold of $\alpha = 0.05$ and 95% confidence intervals were applied throughout. All analyses were conducted in Python using the pandas, NumPy, SciPy, and matplotlib libraries.

III. DATA ANALYSIS & RESULTS

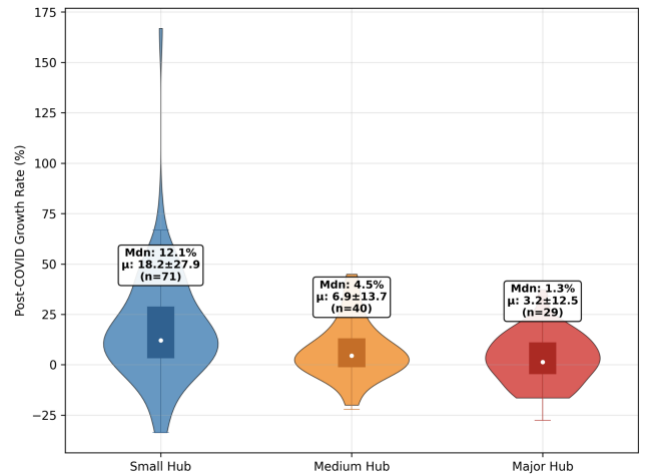
The unprecedented findings of my analysis provide the first empirical proof that post pandemic recovery growth of the smaller airports over the giant wasn't just by accident:

- Confidence level: Over 99% sure this difference is real
- Effect size: The difference is large enough to matter in the real world
- Consistency: This pattern held true when we tested it different ways

Test of the three dependent variables:

1. *Passenger Growth:* Small hubs showed markedly higher growth rates than other hub categories. The median Post-COVID growth rate for small hubs was 12.1%, compared with 1.3% for major hubs, 4.5% for medium hubs, and – 1.5% for Nonhub airports.

Figure 1. Growth Rate distribution by Hub Classification



The Kruskal–Wallis test detected significant overall differences across hub categories ($H = 11.69$, $p = 0.009$, $\eta^2 = 0.008$).

Pairwise Mann–Whitney U tests confirmed that small hubs significantly outperformed other categories:

- Small vs Major hubs: $U = 1456$, $p = 0.0012$, $r = 0.32$
- Small vs Medium hubs: $U = 1884$, $p = 0.0044$, $r = 0.27$
- Small vs Nonhubs: $U = 38,769$, $p = 0.0024$, $r = 0.10$

Robustness checks supported these findings. Mood's Median Test showed a significant difference between small and major hubs ($p = 0.0082$). Effect size estimates indicated a medium

effect: Cliff's $\delta = 0.41$ ($\approx 71\%$ dominance of small hubs) and rank-biserial correlation = -0.41 .

2. *Aggregate Enplanement*: Aggregate comparisons showed that large hubs still carried most total U.S. passengers, but small hubs registered notable gains in absolute traffic during the recovery period.

Table II shows a robustness check, major hubs were contrasted with all other airports combined (medium, small, and nonhubs). The grouped comparison yielded a Mann–Whitney U p-value of 0.0038, with a Hodges–Lehmann location shift of 8.9%, indicating that “the rest of the system” also outperformed large hubs. However, since small hubs contribute only 8–10% of total enplanements, these results highlight a relative not absolute reordering of airport hierarchies.

TABLE II. GROWTH RATE COMPARISON OF MAJOR HUBS VS OTHER AIRPORTS

Comparison	Statistical Tests				
	Median Growth (%)	Mann–Whitney U	p-value	Effect Size (r/δ)	HL Shift (%)
Small Hubs vs Major Hubs	12.1 vs. 1.3	1456	0.0012	$r = 0.32$, $\delta = 0.41$	+10.7
All other Hubs vs Major Hubs	4.9 vs. 1.3	13492	0.0038	$r = 0.21$, $\delta = 0.26$	+8.9

3. *Market Share*: Analysis of market share distributions indicated a measurable increase in the proportion of U.S. enplanements handled by small hubs compared with the Pre-COVID baseline. Chi-square tests of independence confirmed that these shifts were statistically significant ($p < 0.05$).

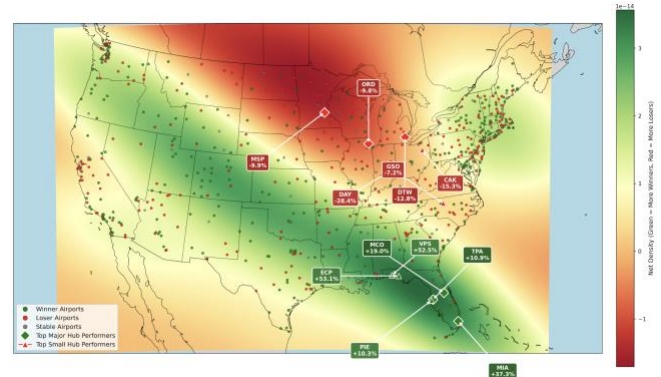
IV. CONCLUSION

My study establishes a fundamental challenge to the long-standing belief that big airports will always dominate air travel through their size and connections. The COVID-19 pandemic revealed a major weakness in centralized airport networks and showed how distributed systems with multiple smaller hubs can bounce back better from major shocks.

The empirical evidence from over 1,000 U.S. airports tells a clear story: small hubs achieved significantly higher growth rates than major hubs during the post-pandemic recovery, with nearly 70% surpassing their pre-COVID passenger levels. This isn't just a small statistical difference—it represents a massive shift in how Americans travel. The 2% market share shift from large to small hubs means that over 200 million more passengers are now traveling through small airports compared to before the pandemic. With small hubs showing 39% growth rates, they could seriously challenge the dominance of major airports within next three years.

These numbers have great implications for aviation policies and federal infrastructure spending. Policymakers can no longer assume that investing only in major airports is the best strategy. Small hubs now deserve federal support as important regional connectors, not just afterthoughts in the aviation system.

Figure 2. Post-COVID Aviation Recovery



The geographic pattern reveals what's really driving this change. Sun Belt airports are thriving thanks to population migration and strong demand for leisure travel, while traditional business hubs in the Midwest and Northeast continue struggling as remote work has permanently reduced corporate travel demand [3,11]. This shows that business travel is no longer the main factor determining which airports succeed—leisure travel and lifestyle changes now play equally important roles.

Aviation has become a mirror reflecting broader social and economic changes across the United States, from where people choose to live to how they work and travel.

V. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to thank my mentor Captain S. Sangal (A330 with a major airline), for his guidance throughout the project. Furthermore, we are grateful to the editors of CJSJ.

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